

This is an open-ended research paper for Anthropology of Latin America whose only requirement was for the research topic to pertain to Latin America and to relate to course themes. It encouraged me to practice “exploring open-ended topics, refining a research thesis, and situating [my] work in relation to that of other scholars”

Damas y Caballeros: Gender Relations Within Mexican Charrería and Beyond

Amid chaos and combustion, smoke makes way for the thunderous woman. Her sparks ignite equal courage as she gallops through the revolution, her ashes rekindled by a younger flame. Behind cast iron and glass, the elegant display veils her wild eyes that observe kerosene one step from the latch. Inspired by women of revolutions, women in Mexico celebrate their heritage as *escaramuzas* in Charrería, Mexico’s national sport. With their only event often reduced to aesthetic, tensions arise within the male-dominated sport. I argue that challenging and redefining machismo in Mexican Charrería has the potential to both promote inclusivity and preserve heritage, and, being the country’s national sport, could potentially influence Mexican society at large.

Mexican Charrería is a sport rooted in tradition. Originating from the 16th-19th century Hacienda period of Mexico, modern Charrería is a cultural performance that honors the country’s traditional equestrian and livestock practices. Charreadas—Charrería performances—consist of ten scored events, with most based on traditional practices: *cala* is an individual reining competition in which riders showcase their equestrian skills by performing a sliding stop, *cabriolas* (spins), and backing their horse to the other end of the arena in a straight line; *piales en el lienzo* is a team competition in which riders gradually bring a galloping wild mare to a stop by roping her hind legs without causing injury, derived from the ranching skills used in horse taming; *coleaderos* involves “tailing” wild bulls in which riders on horseback throw bulls to the

ground by grabbing their tails—this is the modern, less harmful version of the pre-roping practice of striking cattle with clubs to bring them to the ground; *escaramuza*, either following the *coleaderos* or pushed to the final event, is an all-female equestrian drill team performance ridden sidesaddle, showcasing a combination of athleticism and elegance influenced by the “much more active riding style” that women developed as a result of their “roles as stock handlers, couriers, and fighters” in the ranching and civil wars that demanded more from them than riding “sedately in processions”; *jinete de novillos* is a bull riding event in which, unlike the eight-second rides of rodeos in the United States, riders attempt to remain on the bull for as long as possible—this event does not represent any particular ranching skill, but instead is a test of strength and bravery; *terna en el ruedo* is a team roping event in which the objective is not to just rope the steer but to skillfully perform traditional roping patterns; *jinete de yegua* entails riding a wild mare “until she becomes calm and can be dismounted quietly”, a practice of wild horse taming; *manganas a pie* in which competitors rope a wild mare while on foot (similar to *terna en el ruedo*, competitors demonstrate different roping styles, but unlike *piales en el lienzo* where the mare is gradually slowed, competitors bring mares “to the ground in a shoulder roll”); *manganas a caballo*, which is the same as *manganas a pie* but instead on horseback; and *paso de la muerte* (“death leap”), the final charreada competition event which involves a rider leaping onto the back of a wild mare from the back of his own horse at a gallop—a practice derived directly from the Hacienda period (Sands 8-17). Throughout the majority of these events, themes of machismo are fiercely upheld. Aside from the all-female *escaramuzas*, the rest of the charreada events are markedly male. Within those events, violent displays of dominance both reinforce and are enabled by a strong culture of machismo. While most of the events employ the general concept of dominance (including dominance over other men), the use of wild mares in several events

eerily emulates violence against women: *piales en el lienzo* first subdues her carefully—”without injury”—by maintaining a loose rope around her feet, warning her of the power that could escalate; *jinete de yegua* is for the more rowdy, clamping onto her back in a show of dominance until she learns that “calm” is easier than resistance; *manganas a pie y a caballo* shows her that she can and will be taken down by force; and *paso de la muerte* reminds her that the method of her ultimate fate is never certain at the hands of men. This analogy of mares as women becomes even more clear when considering the colloquial usage of *yegua* to refer to women, including as a derogatory term. Through critical analysis of the events, it becomes apparent that the “manners and virtues of the gentleman rider” that the renaissance of charreada aims to preserve reinforce a machismic status quo (Sands 1993, 78).

After being overlooked throughout history, women have made their presence known in Mexican Charrería. Inspired by female revolutionaries in the War for Independence and the Mexican Revolution, the *escaramuza* event in Charrería is an opportunity for women to celebrate their heritage and honor the courageous women who fought for independence. Despite their legacy of bravery and courage being on par with that of the men, the secondary treatment of the *escaramuzas* reflects the normative ambivalence pertaining to the societal role of women in Mexican culture (Sands 1993, 177). The *escaramuza* event was added to charreadas as a performance in 1953—this was the same year women in Mexico gained the right to vote, suggesting a correlation between women’s status in charrería and their status in Mexican society. *Escaramamaza* officially became a competitive charreada event in 1992. Along with the fact that there is only one event for women and nine others for men, the *escaramuza* event is largely treated as “secondary”. Many *escaramuzas* ride horses that are also being ridden in other charreada events as many belong to male members of their families—as a result, so as to avoid

their horses being too tired for other events, there is an “unwritten rule” that expects an *escaramuza* to hand over the horse she rides to the man who owns them; furthermore, the men are the ones who decide the placement of the *escaramuza* event in the charreada schedule, as “they see [the men's events] as significantly more important” (Sands 1993, 162-163). As it can be inferred that the men’s events are more respected due to their adherence to machismic ideals of courage and strength, it is reasonable to assume that there is potential for *escaramuza* to garner greater respect (and thus better treatment) if more emphasis is placed on the courage and strength of the *escaramuzas* and the revolutionary women they are inspired by. Of course, such a strategy that works within the system can only address so much—even the administration of the sport itself “structurally perpetuates and legitimises unequal power relations”, with only two women providing input on the 2020-2024 Charrería National Board of Directors alongside twenty-six men (Monterrubio et al. 2024, 9). It is commonly expected for *escaramuzas* to retire from their active riding careers upon marriage, and many former *escaramuzas* “often express deep regret and a sense of being deprived of an important identity factor in their lives” (Sands 1993, 184). This sentiment echoes the common story of women globally who abandon their pursuits in order to “fulfill their domestic roles” as many patriarchal cultures promote—the “wild” woman is “tamed” once she “settles down with a man”. Women’s participation in *escaramuza* and Charrería provides the opportunity to empower women, so long as their power is recognized.

Redefining machismo has the potential to benefit marginalized groups and the sport as a whole. Within Charrería, there is already growing support for the further inclusion of women. Recently, some unofficial women’s and mixed teams have been established (Monterrubio and Dashper, 2024). In their 2024 research, Monterrubio and Dashper conducted several interviews

pertaining to women in Charrería: in one of their interviews, a *charro* who “is against the exclusion of women in the sport” shared that “[women] practise all the suertes and do not do it badly, they are capable, they have no limits”; in another interview, another *charro* shares that he “know[s] of three women who ride bulls; they can be just as good or even better than us men”. The integration of women in other equestrian and rodeo sports outside of Charrería can provide valuable insight into what sex integration could mean for women interested in Charrería. In rural Mexico, women compete alongside men. Though sex integration in the sport does not solve all of its sex-based discrimination, it challenges machismo by forefronting “women who can be recognized as brave and capable” (Monterrubio and Dashper, 2024). In an interview with a female rider, she shares how “people wanted to take pictures with [her] because [she] had won and some girls came up saying they also want to ride”, illustrating how the inclusion of women in male-dominated sports is inspiring and empowering (Monterrubio and Dashper, 2024). In another interview, a male farrier who used to ride commented that “female riders are very brave...sometimes they have more capability than a man”, which he then qualified with “although it also depends on the horse”; while there is still underlying bias against women, it is clear that sex integration has the potential to encourage a more inclusive environment (Monterrubio and Dashper, 2024). In Brazil—a country with a strong culture of machismo—women compete in *campeiro* rodeo, sometimes alongside men, and other times in their own women’s categories (differentiated with slight adjustments, such as lighter ropes than the men for roping) (Adelman and Becker 2013). Responses to their inclusion are mixed, with not only some men opposing their involvement, but some women as well; women’s participation in masculinized sports such as rodeo is perceived as a threat to “traditional” norms of male dominance and domestic femininity (Adelman and Becker 2013). With this in mind, it is

unsurprising that many women entering male-dominated fields feel pressure to either perform or reject femininity. This phenomenon is present in Brazil's *campeiro* rodeos, and it brings homophobic sentiments to light, as an interview with a woman who was among the first to compete in her region's rodeos reveals how she faced questioning and accusations of potential homosexuality because of her participation in the sport (Adelman and Becker 2013). These accusations play a role in what is termed "homohysteria", which refers to the phenomenon in which individuals act a certain way (or rather, avoid acting certain ways) out of "fear of being socially perceived as gay", and often leads individuals to perpetuate the same homophobia that causes this phenomenon in an effort to avoid becoming targets themselves (Piedra, García-Pérez, and Channon 2021). As machismo harms gender and sexual minorities (as well as individuals who simply do not conform to cultural norms), challenges to machismo (i.e. further inclusion of women in male-dominated sports such as Mexican Charrería) provide an opportunity for intersectional empowerment. Redefining who can display courage and strength is not the only approach to challenging machismo in Charrería—another promising approach challenges machismo in Charrería by refining courage and strength itself. It is no secret that Charrería and other animal-related sports are often criticized out of concerns for animal welfare. While there are participants who value animal welfare, the violence of dominance that machismo rewards enables individuals to disregard animal welfare if they so choose. Redefining what it means to be a good, well-respected animal handler by emphasizing the strength and courage that gentler practices require could prove very powerful in revolutionizing the sport. When it comes to preserving tradition (as is integral to the existence of Charrería), all efforts may eventually become futile if the sport loses its "social license" (ability to operate as granted by public acceptance); as there are growing calls for better promotion of animal welfare in equine sports

globally, it is reasonable to anticipate that the legacy of Charrería is at stake (Monterrubio, Dashper, and Wadham 2023). Preserving the culture of Charrería “requires adaptation to new social and environmental circumstances”, suggesting that redefining what machismo means to the sport may be necessary for its survival (Sands 1993, 222).

As Mexican Charrería is deeply tied to national heritage, it is unreasonable to expect the sport to change overnight—more importantly, it is unreasonable for it to be abandoned altogether. By identifying the ways in which the sport causes harm and addressing harm in ways that still respect heritage, Charrería can be both protected and reinvented for generations to come. The past can only be preserved if the present sees a future.

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